FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

As astronaut Shubhanshu Shukla landed in Delhi back in August after his historic journey in space, there was a flutter of excitement across the country. He met the prime minister and held press conferences. But there is still great curiosity about his experience and many unanswered questions. In this issue, we bring you those answers. Straight from Shux, as he is called, in an exclusive, full-length interview with Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa, a space chronicler since Rakesh Sharma's 1984 mission. He has also written on Kalpana Chawla and Sunita Williams. Together, they tease out not just the science and the adventure, but the inner transformation an astronaut undergoes while floating in outer space. "I would sit by the window and stare at Earth for hours. No thoughts, no worries, no questions. Time stops," Shux says. "You realise everything, everyone you know, all of history, happened there. You feel your insignificance."

When Shukla floated across the open hatch of SpaceX's Crew Dragon shuttle into the vast interiors of the International Space Station (ISS), he inscribed his own chapter in history. If Rakesh Sharma was the first Indian in space in 1984, Shukla became the second, but with a distinction. He was the first Indian to live and work on the ISS, conducting experiments in an orbiting laboratory that has been humanity's joint venture since 2000. Some 285 astronauts from 23 countries had been there before him, yet Shukla's journey had a special resonance. It was India's first step into a future that promises to be much larger. Prime Minister Narendra Modi has cleared a bold and wholly India-driven space exploration calendar. At the heart of it is Gaganyaan, India's maiden human spaceflight that the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) has scheduled for 2027. Shukla, one of four Indian Air Force test pilots shortlisted for the mission, was in effect on reconnaissance, scouting for a nation.

The next step promises to be even more of a milestone. By 2035, India plans to have its own Bharatiya Antariksh Station, which will be only the third space station in orbit after the ISS and China's ongoing Tiangong programme. By 2040, the target is more audacious still: to place an Indian on the Moon, on an Indian spacecraft. ISRO picked Shukla for the Axiom-4 mission precisely to gain the first-hand experience that will feed these coming human spaceflights. It cost $500 million, but what he brought back is priceless. No simulator can replicate what he went through: the compression of sitting atop 400,000 kg of rocket fuel as a Falcon-9 roared skyward, the docking with the ISS, the days in microgravity, the re-entry. Nor the seven experiments he conducted in orbit, including one on stem cells and muscle degeneration, which could reshape medical science here on Earth.



▲ **Jul. 14, 2025**



▲ **Jan. 13, 2003**



▲ **Apr. 30, 1984**

Shukla's voyage lasted 20 days, longer than Sharma's week in space, with 18 days on board the ISS, which he jokingly calls a "6BHK in size". A fighter pilot used to dizzying altitudes, he discovered a new scale of awe. From 400 km above Earth, orbiting at 28,000 kmph and circling the planet 16 times a day, he saw what few ever will: our blue world suspended in the void. His descriptions slake our wonder and curiosity. How does one eat in near-zero gravity? What do you do to stop your lunch from floating? How does the body react to prolonged weightlessness? What does it take to sleep while tethered to a wall? And beyond the practical, the philosophical: what is it like to see all of human history compressed into that orb beneath? How does it feel to gaze at Earth and know that all of civilisation rests on that fragile sphere?

At 40, Shux is already shaping a new generation's imagination. His story urges young Indians to dream of space, science and discovery. He admits he was reluctant to return, his mind already on India's first Moon mission. "I tell the kids, maybe one of you will walk on the Moon. But I will be fighting you for it," he laughs. For now, enjoy this sparkling interview with the man who brought outer space a little closer home. And a Happy Diwali!



(Aroon Purie)